of financial devices, then computers are poised to amass far more power than humans.

Computers can connect in unlimited numbers, and they understand at least some financial and legal realities better than many humans. When the central bank raises interest rates by 0.25 per cent, how does that influence the economy? When the yield curve of government bonds goes up, is it a good time to buy them? When is it advisable to short the price of oil? These are the kinds of important financial questions that computers can already answer better than most humans. No wonder that computers make a larger and larger percentage of the financial decisions in the world. We may reach a point when computers dominate the financial markets, and invent completely new financial tools beyond our understanding.

The same is true of laws. How many people know all the tax laws of their country? Even professional accountants struggle with that. But computers are built for such things. They are bureaucratic natives and can automatically draft laws, monitor legal violations and identify legal loopholes with superhuman efficiency.[30]

HACKING THE OPERATING SYSTEM OF HUMAN CIVILISATION

When computers were first developed in the 1940s and 1950s, many people believed that they would be good only at computing numbers. The idea that they would one day master the intricacies of language, and of linguistic creations like laws and currencies, was confined largely to the realm of science fiction. But by the early 2020s, computers had demonstrated a remarkable ability to analyze, manipulate and generate language, whether with words, sounds, images or code symbols. As I write this, computers can tell stories, compose music, fashion images, produce videos and even write their own code.[31]

By gaining such command of language, computers are seizing the master key unlocking the doors of all our institutions, from banks to temples. We use language to create not just legal codes and financial devices but also art, science, nations and religions. What would it mean for humans to live in a world where catchy melodies, scientific theories, technical tools, political manifestos and even religious myths are shaped by a non-human alien